Bihari Mal: Embattled heir to the Kachhwaha throne. Became Akbar's first Rajput ally – and father-in-law – when he married his daughter, Harkha, to Akbar

Harkha Bai: Kachhwaha princess, Akbar's first Rajput wife and mother of his first son, Salim

Bhagwant Das: Harkha's brother and Akbar's brother-in-law. Attained high rank in Akbar's court; married his daughter to Akbar's firstborn son (also Bhagwant Das's nephew)

Man Singh: Harkha's nephew and brother-in-law to Akbar's firstborn son. One of Akbar's star generals and among the most powerful men in his court

Salim: Akbar's eldest son. Born of Harkha as the boon Akbar sought from God, Salim became the bane of Akbar's old age. Led the last prominent rebellion against Akbar and succeeded him as Jahangir

Man Bai: Salim's first wife, Bhagwant Das's daughter, and mother to Salim's first son, Khusro

Salima Sultan: Akbar's cousin, Bairam Khan's widow and thereafter Akbar's wife. A trusted adviser to the family, played a key role in negotiations between Akbar and Salim

Murad: Akbar's second son. A favourite of his Jesuit tutor Father Antonio Monserrate, unpopular with Akbar's nobility. Died while Akbar lived

Daniyal: Akbar's youngest son. Enjoyed hunting, horses and poetry. Died while Akbar lived, despite Akbar's desperate efforts to save him

Khusro: Salim's first son. A favourite of Akbar's and a contender for his throne

Foster Family, Family Friends and Frenemies

Maham Anaka:[2] Generally, and incorrectly, said to be Akbar's foster mother; more likely the superintendent of his nurses. Loving, protective and ambitious, she played a prominent role in the early years of Akbar's reign

Adham Khan: Maham Anaka's son. Memorably and brutally executed by Akbar for murdering Akbar's foster father

Shamsuddin Muhammad Ataka:[3] Akbar's foster father and his attendant from Akbar's infancy. Loyal and ambitious, rose to a high rank during Akbar's reign before being killed by Adham Khan. His family remained